On November 12, I discovered that Camp Lee had an excellent library and thereafter I spent as much time there as I could. The Army was a bore and it offered endless humiliations to privates, but it did offer ways of passing the time that weren't entirely unwelcome.

My first mail arrived on the thirteenth—one letter from Marcia and one from Stanley. The next day there arrived the first letter from Gertrude—four pages, which I read and reread until the ink grew faint from repeated eye contact.

On the fifteenth, I received a letter from Machlowitz. He had seen Gertrude over the weekend and, with his usual tact, told me she seemed tired and strained. Somehow the letter gave me the impression that it was my fault. A better husband would not have consulted his selfish desires and run off to join the Army.

I learned new ways of life in the Army. I learned how to take showers in public—or at least with other young men surrounding me.

I did not enjoy it. I don't think I would have minded if it were young women surrounding me, but I have always found the sight of naked men repulsive in the extreme. 2 I was aware of this first at my very first Army physical when, for the first time, I saw a line of men with their genitals dangling. I wondered then (and I wonder now) how women can bear it.

Worse yet, I learned, or attempted to learn, how to defecate in public. In latrine after latrine, the seats were arranged in long rows without the sketchiest partitions between them. Other soldiers seemed not to mind, but I took to waking myself at 3:00 a.m. in order to have the latrine to myself. It never worked; I don't think I ever walked in without finding at least one other soldier there.

2 If there is any amateur psychologist who thinks this bespeaks some hidden homosexual impulse in me, he or she is welcome to continue thinking so en route to Hell.

3

I tried to go through channels in order to see if I could avoid basic training and simply be assigned to some appropriate job in the Army. It seemed reasonable to me that this be done in view of my AGCT score, and my experience as a chemist. Add to this the fact that the war was over and that I wasn't ever going to be doing anything that required military drill and setting-